Alessandro Balbina

Ph.D. Student in Economics and Business (41st Cycle)

Department of Economics and Business Sciences | University of Cagliari, Italy

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Tourism Economics, Artificial Intelligence & Chatbot Adoption in Tourism, Sustainable Destination Management, Microeconometrics, Regional Economics, Spatial Data Analysis & GIS.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics and Business (41st Cycle) **Nov 2025 – Present**

University of Cagliari, Department of Economics and Business Sciences *Cagliari, Italy*

- **Focus:** Consumer adoption of Generative AI and conversational chatbots for travel planning, booking behaviors, and sustainable destination discovery using mixed qualitative and quantitative econometric methodologies.
- **Supervisors:** Prof. Cinzia Dessì (Supervisor), Prof. Ivan Etzo (Co-supervisor).

M.Sc. in Sustainable Tourism Management and Monitoring **2022 – 2025**

University of Cagliari *Cagliari, Italy*

- **Grade:** 110/110 cum laude (with honors).
- **Master's Thesis:** *"Tourism data, sustainability and shadow tourism estimates. Case study of the municipality of Cagliari"*.

B.Sc. in Communication Sciences **2017 – 2022**

University of Cagliari *Cagliari, Italy*

- **Grade:** 106/110.
- **Bachelor's Thesis:** *"Rebrand and social media strategy: The case of the agricultural company 'Opuntia'"*.

PUBLICATIONS & SCIENTIFIC CONTRIBUTIONS

Conference Papers & Proceedings

- **Balbina, A.**, Vincis, A., & Dessì, C. (2026). *"Driving Sustainable Destinations through Digital Transformation: A Qualitative Inquiry into Local SMEs in Sardinia"*. **6th ICEM Conference 2026**, Valencia, Spain (Conference Abstract, Presented Remotely).
- Vincis, A., Tedde, D., **Balbina, A.**, & Dessì, C. (2026). *"AI Literacy as a Hiring Signal in Project Management Recruitment"*. **Sinergie-SIMA Management Conference 2026 Proceedings**, University of Pavia, ISBN: 979-12-243-4261-8.
- Dessì, C., Vincis, A., **Balbina, A.**, & Succa, A. (2026). *"Dual-Speed Transformation After Succession: Why Family Business Groups Change while Staying the Same"*. **Sinergie-SIMA Management Conference 2026 Proceedings**, University of Pavia, ISBN: 979-12-243-4261-8.

Working Papers & Book Chapters

- Dessì, C., Vincis, A., & **Balbina, A.** (In press). *"People Management in AI-Enabled SMEs: A Human-Centered Capability Perspective"*. Book chapter in *Innovation in Human Centered Sustainability: Human Centered Sustainability in the AI Age*.
- **Balbina, A.** (Working Paper). *"Adoption of Artificial Intelligence by Tourists: A Literature Review"*. Working paper on generative trip planning and booking behavior.

Presentations & Invited Talks

- Dessì, C. & **Balbina, A.** (2026). *"Cineturismo, immaginario audiovisivo e territorio: dalla letteratura internazionale al caso locale de L'Isola di Pietro"*. Invited lecture at *Ogni film è un viaggio*, Società Umanitaria, Cagliari, Italy.

Honors & Academic Awards

- **Outstanding Young Scholar Reviewer Award (2026)** – Sinergie-SIMA Management Conference.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Consultant for Local Development and Tourism (Higher Apprenticeship) **Apr 2025 – Dec 2025**
Rete Gaia *Sardinia, Italy (Hybrid)*

- Designed and coordinated local sustainable tourism development initiatives, evaluating territorial supply and demand trends across regional municipalities.
- Spearheaded market research, strategic positioning, and content development for the *Sardinian Roots* diaspora tourism project and *Italea Sardegna*.
- Built automated data collection scripts in Python to analyze accommodation offerings and regional pricing benchmarks.

Data Analyst (Internship) **Sep 2024 – Dec 2024**
Municipality of Cagliari, Tourism Office *Cagliari, Italy*

- Conducted statistical analyses on municipal tourism datasets, short-term rental dynamics, and seasonal capacity indicators.
- Designed analytical dashboards and reports for municipal policymakers to quantify unofficial and non-hotel tourism accommodations.

University Tutor – B.Sc. in Economics and Business Management **Nov 2023 – Sep 2024**
University of Cagliari *Cagliari, Italy (Hybrid)*

- Mentored and supported over 300+ undergraduate students across economics, business management, and foundational coursework.
- Organized and invigilated formal national TOLC admission examinations; automated student credit transfer and CFU verification flows.

Research Contributor **2025**
Sardinian Roots Project (e.INS) *Cagliari, Italy*

- Contributed to quantitative and qualitative research on roots tourism, designing tailored visitor pathways for the global Sardinian diaspora.

Airport Ground Handling Agent (Seasonal) **Jun 2018 – Oct 2022**
SOGAERDYN S.p.A. – Cagliari-Elmas International Airport (CAG) *Cagliari, Italy*

- Managed front-line passenger reception, flight check-in, documentation compliance, and boarding operations across 4 high-intensity summer seasons (4 years, 5 months cumulative).
- Utilized specialized departure control systems (**Altéa Departure Control System - Amadeus**, **iPort**) under strict punctuality and aviation safety guidelines.

LEADERSHIP & COMMUNITY SERVICE

Scout Leader & Youth Educator **2018 – Present**
AGESCI (Italian Catholic Guides and Scouts Association) *Cagliari, Italy*

- 18+ years of active scouting background; leading and mentoring youth groups (ages 8–19) in team collaboration, environmental ethics, and active citizenship.
- Coordinated complex logistical operations, high-altitude wilderness treks, multi-day camps, and risk-managed outdoor expeditions.

SKILLS & CERTIFICATIONS

Statistical, Econometric & Programming: Python (Pandas, NumPy, Scikit-learn, Matplotlib, Data Scraping), R (Tidyverse, plm, ggplot2), Stata, SQL, Advanced Microsoft Excel, Git/GitHub.

Spatial Analysis & Specialized Software: Geographic Information Systems (QGIS / GIS), Open Data Mapping, Amadeus Altéa DCS Suite, iPort.

Languages (CEFR): Italian (Native, C2), Sardinian (Native), English (C1 – Professional Working Proficiency), Spanish (A2 – Elementary), Dutch (A1 – Basic).

Certifications & Driving: • IBSEN Entrepreneurship Workshop Series (IBSEN Network, Feb 2025).
• BLSD – Basic Life Support Defibrillation (Ircomunità A.p.s., ID: 20220000235718, valid through Jun 2026).
• Driving Licenses: Italian Categories A, B.